Middle East Weekly Review

October 26 to November 1, 2026

- **Week in brief:** Israel voted without producing a majority for either bloc (53, 48 and 19 seats), Iran moved from “no talks” to calling Vance’s letter a positive step while still planning no meeting, Brent ended October at $117.64 (up 13.6% on the month, up about 0.8% on the week), and the KOSPI swung from a 6,012.44 record-day close to 5,730.74, ending the week 3.3% higher.

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1. The Week’s Arc

The week opened with Egypt’s parliament authorizing military support for Saudi Arabia, a Houthi missile fired at Riyadh’s airport hours after it reopened, and Saudi, Pakistani and Turkish officials meeting Iranians in Tehran. Israel voted on October 27 and the count settled at 53 for Netanyahu’s bloc, 48 for Eisenkot’s and 19 for Arab parties, with Netanyahu alleging a stolen vote and the Knesset due to be sworn in on November 10. Last week’s structural story was a Houthi front reaching Saudi Arabia’s core; this week’s is that the front stayed active while diplomacy acquired a channel: Qatari mediators in Tehran, a Vance letter that the WSJ reported on October 28, and an Iranian aide in Doha by Saturday.

Maritime risk shifted from Iranian claims to deniable attacks. On October 29 the tanker Louise 1 burned after limpet mines were attached off Khasab, unclaimed, and on Friday the IRGC said four more tankers hit mines on “unauthorised routes,” which CENTCOM and Treasury Secretary Bessent contradicted by saying routes are cleared and transit is near prewar. Iran’s Persian Gulf Strait Authority turned on Korea’s Sinokor, announcing legal action against all its ships from November 1. On Washington’s side Trump kept saying Iran “wants to talk” and the war ends “very soon,” the Pentagon briefed post midterm options, and on Saturday Rubio said no decision has been made. The week ends one election day short of the pledge window: the November 3 midterms, then the strike tests of November 4 and 6.

In Korea, the KOSPI fell 1.46% to 5,469.47 on October 26, rose 3.09% on October 27, jumped 6.63% to 6,012.44 on October 28 after SK Hynix’s record profit, then fell 1.24% and 3.48% as Samsung’s deferred buyback details and Alphabet’s AI spending worries hit chips. Seoul’s visible response to the Sinokor warning was silence.

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2. Indicator Scoreboard

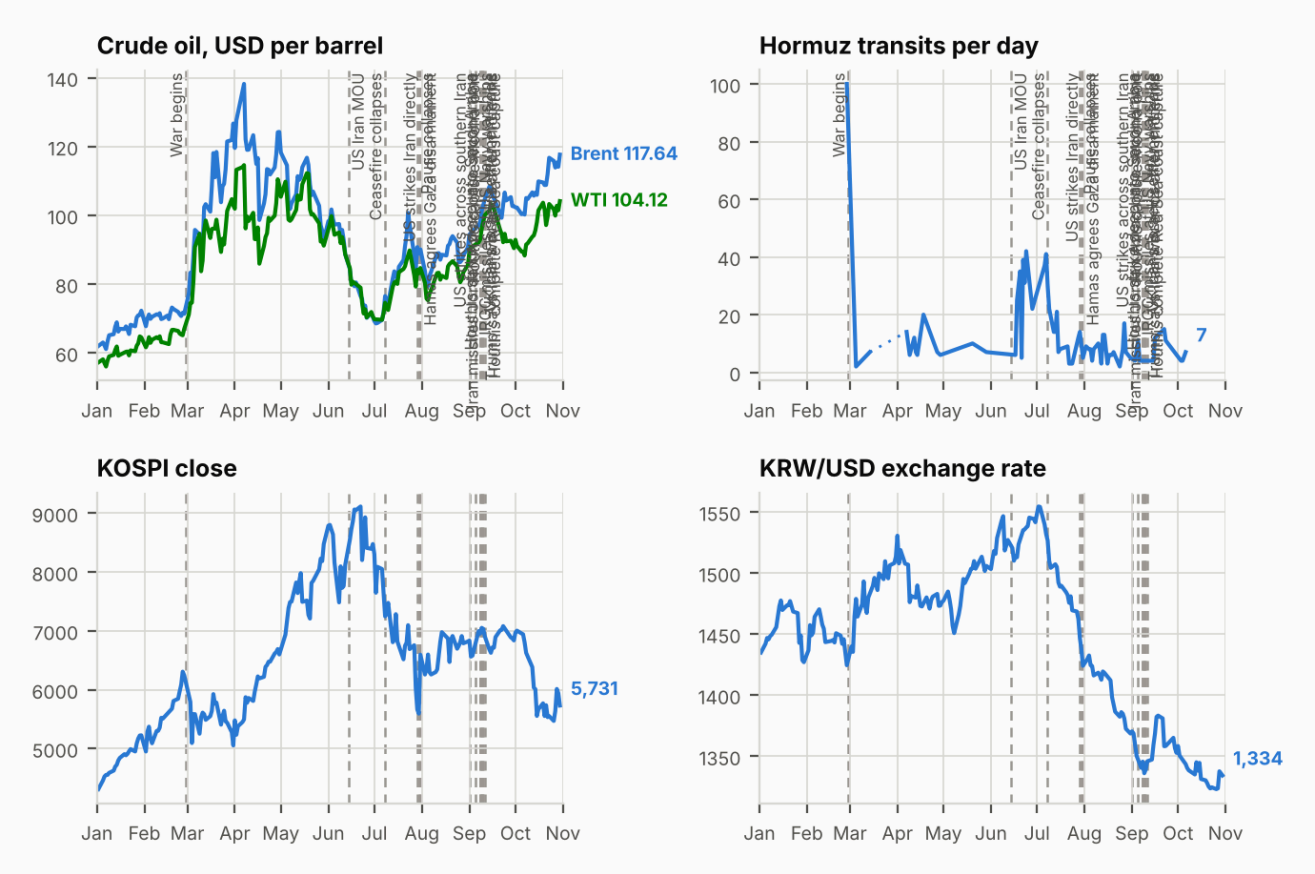
22 indicators were opened this week (IND-20261026-1 through IND-20261101-3) and 19 were resolved: **4 confirmed**, **8 falsified** and **7 expired**. Falsified include IND-20261024-1 (no US escorted convoy or IRGC attack on a US base), IND-20261026-1 (no disclosed US-Iran session by October 31), IND-20261028-1 (neither Israeli bloc reached 61) and the Brent and KOSPI price bands of October 24 and 26 (no Brent settle above $120 or below $110, no KOSPI close below 5,300). Expired include IND-20261023-2 (Dhahran evacuation or confirmed outage, never confirmed) and IND-20261026-3 (no weekly UKMTO tally). **22 indicators remain open**; the nearest deadlines are IND-20261030-2 (Seoul on Sinokor, November 2) and IND-20261030-3 (KOSPI above 6,000, November 2), and the longest is IND-20260910-3 (Trump’s “war ends after the election,” November 17).

Calibration note: Again the price-level calls were the ones that failed: the KOSPI bands were set too tight for a week in which a single day (October 28, +6.63%) moved the index more than the week’s net change, and the

diplomatic indicators resolved falsified because Tehran kept saying it would not meet. Open ended diplomatic wording (“a disclosed session”) is hard to falsify cleanly, so new diplomatic indicators should name an observable source and a close date.

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3. Data Trends



Brent settled at $115.81 (Oct 26), $113.88 (Oct 27), $115.32 (Oct 28) and $117.64 (Oct 30, expiring December contract; the January contract settled at $113.43), about 0.8% above the $116.72 of Oct 23; the Oct 29 settle was not found. WTI settled at $101.76, $99.90, $102.78 and $104.12, also about 0.8% higher than $103.27, so the Brent-WTI spread held near $13.5. KOSPI closed at 5,469.47, 5,638.34, 6,012.44, 5,937.66 and 5,730.74, 3.3% above 5,550.30 on Oct 23, though the week’s range (5,469 to 6,012) was about three times the net change. The won closed between 1,323.1 and 1,337.7 per dollar, ending at 1,334.3 (Oct 30), about 0.7% weaker than the 1,324.6 of a week earlier; the Oct 29 close was not found. Hormuz: no exact daily count was found, and Bessent’s “near prewar” claim and the IRGC’s four mine hits cannot both describe the same traffic.

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4. Slow Threads

- **Qatar’s Ras Laffan LNG loadings (IND-20260714-4):** still no fresh weekly figure.
- **Saudi East-West pipeline throughput (IND-20260923-1):** no new estimate; deadline November 3, and Houthi strikes on Saudi energy sites raise its importance.
- **Sinokor enforcement (IND-20261029-1, IND-20261030-2):** the November 1 deadline passed with no Korean government statement found.

- **Post midterm planning (IND-20261023-3):** strike tests run to November 6.
- **Egypt’s deployment to Saudi Arabia (IND-20261027-1):** authorized October 26, no confirmed arrival.
- **Israeli government formation (IND-20261028-2):** Herzog’s mandate is due after the November 10 swearing in.

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5. Revisions and Lessons

No material correction to `instructions/korea-exposure.md` was needed. The October 31 daily’s Brent ($117.62 intraday, no settle) and WTI (unreported) were corrected in the November 1 daily with Reuters settles of $117.64 and $104.12. Lessons: a Friday settle missed on a weekend run can be recovered the next morning from Reuters via CNBC, so the first search on any Saturday or Sunday run should be the prior day’s settle; the expiring contract (December) and the active contract (January) differed by $4.21, so the series should record which contract it follows; and wire claims by the IRGC about tanker hits should stay at Low confidence until an operator, UKMTO or JMIC confirms.